

Session 23: Paul's Prayer for Love

Key Takeaways

- Paul concludes chapter 3 with a prayer that functions as a climactic summary of the core themes of Ephesians 1-3.
- To truly grasp the different dimensions of God's love, we must spend time with fellow Jesus followers who come from diverse backgrounds so that aspects of God's love do not remain beyond our reach.
- Ephesians 3:17 is about deepening our commitment to each other and discovering God's love.

A Prayer for Love Among God's Family: Translation and Literary Design of Ephesians 3:14-21

¹⁴ For this reason,
I bow my knee to the Father,
¹⁵ from whom every family-clan
in the heavens and on the earth
is named,
¹⁶ so that he would give to y'all,
according to the richness of his glory,
power to be strengthened
through his Spirit
in your inner human,
¹⁷ that the Messiah would dwell
in your hearts
through faith,
having been rooted
and established
in love
¹⁸ so that y'all would be **empowered**
to comprehend
along with all of the holy ones
what is the width and length and height and depth—
¹⁹ to know the
far-beyond knowing
love of the Messiah
so that y'all would be filled up
unto all the fullness of God.
²⁰ Now to the one who is powerful
beyond all things
to do overabundantly more
than what we would ask or conceive,
according to the power which is at work in us,
²¹ to him be glory
in the church
and in Messiah Jesus
for all generations of the age of the ages, amen.

Ephesians 3:14-21. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).

Flow of Thought in 3:14-21

Ephesians 3:14-15: Paul prays to the Father of all the “children of God,” both heavenly (i.e., the loyal cosmic forces that have not rebelled) and earthly (i.e., the tribes of humanity unified in the Messiah).

Ephesians 3:16-17: Paul's first request is two-part. He asks for (1a) God to give the people power (cf. 1:19) to enable an inner transformation and be strengthened by the Spirit so that (1b) the Messiah could take up temple residence in their communal hearts as they learn to love and serve one another.

Ephesians 3:18-19: Paul’s second request is also two-part. He asks that this “power” and “presence” would (2a) empower the people to grasp the cosmic scope of God’s love, that is, to (2b) experientially know the love of the Messiah that is beyond our full comprehension so that God’s own life “fills them unto all the fullness of God.”

Ephesians 3:20-21: Paul praises God who is powerful to do beyond what humans can conceive of and acknowledges that God’s power is what’s at work in the Messiah’s people.

The Role of 3:14-21 in the Flow of Ephesians 1-3

This prayer functions as a climactic summary of the core themes of chapters 1-3. Nearly every phrase in 3:14-21 picks up a key image or word from earlier in the letter.

Ephesians 3:14-21		Links Back to Ephesians 1-3
The united heaven and earth and all its human and spiritual inhabitants derive from the creator of all	3:14-15: “I kneel before the Father from whom every family in the heavenly and earthly realms gets its name ”	1:10-11: God’s purpose “to head-up all things together in the Messiah, things in heaven and things on earth ” 1:20-21: God “raised the Messiah from among the dead ones and seated him at his right hand in the heavenly realm , far above all rule and authority and power and dominion and every name which is named ” 2:6: “And [God] raised us with the Messiah and seated us in the heavenly realm ”
	3:16a: “that he would give y’all, according to the richness of his glory ...”	1:7: “in whom we have ... forgiveness of sins, according to the richness of his glory ” 1:18: “that y’all might know what is the hope of his calling and what is the richness of the glory of his inheritance with/among the holy ones.” 2:7: “so that [God] could display ... the richness of his grace , shown by kindness to us in Messiah Jesus.” 3:8: “To me ... was given this grace to announce to the nations the good news of the inexhaustible richness of the Messiah”

Hyperlinks in Ephesians 3. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).

Ephesians 3:14-21

Links Back to Ephesians 1-3

The Spirit takes up residence in the corporate life of his people to give them new power

3:16: "that he would give to y'all ... **power** to be **strengthened** by his **Spirit** in our inner human"

1:18-20: I pray that you might know "what is the surpassing greatness of his **power** towards us who trust, in accordance with **working** of the **might** of his **strength**, which he worked out in the Messiah by raising him from the dead ones ... far above every ... power and dominion."

3:7: "I became a servant [of the good news] according to the gift of God's grace which was given to me according to the **working** of his **power**."

1:17: I pray "that God would give you a **spirit** of wisdom and revelation as you know him"

2:18: "we both have access by one **Spirit** to the Father"

2:22: "y'all are being built together into a dwelling house of God by means of the **Spirit** "

God's new temple/house that is being built according to the house-plan as a place for God to dwell

3:17: "so the Messiah can **dwell** (κατοικησαι) in y'all's hearts through trust ..."

1:10: "the **arranged-house-plan** (οικονομία) of the fulfillment of the times, to head-up all things together in the Messiah"

2:19-22: "y'all are fellow citizens of the holy ones and members (οἰκείοι) of God's **house**, **built** (οικοδομηθέντες) on the foundation of the apostles and prophets, the Messiah Jesus being the cornerstone, in whom the entire **building** (οικοδομη) is fitted together and grows into a holy temple in the Lord, in whom y'all are being **built** together (συνοικοδομεισθε) into a **dwelling place** (κατοικητηριον) of God, by the Spirit"

3:9-10: "the **arranged-house-plan** (οικονομία) of the open-secret ... that now the multi-faceted wisdom of God might be made known through the church to the rulers and authorities in the heavenly realms"

Hyperlinks in Ephesians 3. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).

	Ephesians 3:14-21	Links Back to Ephesians 1-3
God's love is prior to all reality God's new temple and new tree of life	3:17: "as you have been rooted and founded in love "	1:4-5: "having pre-established us in love for adoption through Jesus Messiah" 2:4: "But God, who is rich in mercy, because of the great love with which he loved us " 2:20-21: "having been built on the foundation (θεμελιος) of the apostles and prophets ... y'all grow (αυξει) into a holy temple"
Power to know the true apocalyptic reality	3:18-19a: "that you would have power to comprehend with all of the holy ones ... to know the beyond-knowing love of the Messiah"	1:18: "that that eyes of your heart would be enlightened in order to know ... what is the richness of his inheritance with/among the holy ones"
The church as the new temple filled with God's glory	3:19b: "... so that you are filled up unto all of the fullness of God himself "	1:22-23 "and [God] placed him as head over all things in the church, which is his body, the filled up-ness of the one who fills all things in every way "
Hyperlinks in Ephesians 3. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).		

Reflection Question

There are depths and dimensions of the love of God that are impossible to experience without regularly surrounding ourselves with other followers of Jesus who are not like us. Identify one way that you can live this out practically in your life.